EIGHT

Until then, I was still trying to find a purpose to my existence. But after seeing myself standing all alone in the entire barracks as the recommended candidate, I understood it. Getting recommended was only the beginning. The path to glory was strewn with obstacles, ones that would almost break me.

I spent a lonely night in the barracks the day I was recommended, but I enjoyed a dreamless slumber. The next morning, a Jeep dropped me to the railway station. I reached Bangalore in the afternoon, where another military vehicle had been arranged to drop me to IAM. IAM Bangalore, a premier institute of the Indian Air Force and the hub of aerospace medicine activities in the country, is the only institute of its kind in South Asia for conducting a doctor of medicine (MD) course in aerospace medicine for aircrew, medical officers and paramedics. Upon reaching IAM, I saw that it was a typical air force white-and-sky-blue building with neatly trimmed trees and grass gardens in front. The tricolour was hoisted on a flagpole in front of the building. An attendant took me to their ‘trinity mess’; a big dorm room was allotted to me, where I was told that I would be the only occupant for the next few days—no other SSB medical tests had been scheduled during that time. It felt lonely and depressing to not have any company in such a place. I was told to report to the medical officer’s office